The case, first investigated by the Rajasthan Special Operations Group (SOG), was later handed over to the Central Bureau of Investigation, which registered an FIR under the Public Examinations (Prevention of Unfair Means) Act, 2024, along with charges of cheating and corruption. The early findings make the current disruption seem graver than past breaches. This was not just an external criminal racket gaming the system. It bore the markings of an insider operation.

Leak from the Top

Unlike in the past, the NEET paper this time did not get compromised at a printing press, courier van or exam-hall gate, but at the point where the questions were written and translated, before they ever entered the logistics chain. NEET-UG is set in 13 languages—English, plus 12 regional ones. Once the master paper is finalised in English, it is translated into each language, with a separate back-translation into English to verify accuracy, so that the questions pass through many hands before the paper is sealed. To limit exposure, the NTA sometimes uses the same expert to set the questions as well as translate them. In 2026, that shortcut concentrated access in a few hands.



"The only way forward is to reduce the human element in the exam process. It's not about individuals. It's about the institution. Ultimately, the institution has to be responsible to millions of children, their parents and society at large"

— **Abhishek Singh,** *Director General, NTA*

Two of those experts were Chemistry lecturer P.V. Kulkarni and Biology expert Manisha Gurunath Mandhare. They were both from Pune and had known each other for years. And they had both served as paper-setters and Marathi translators. In the latter capacity, Kulkarni handled the 45 Chemistry questions and Mandhare the 90 Biology ones. Between them, they had access to all 135 Biology and Chemistry questions.

Late in April, the CBI alleges, Kulkarni put that access to use, running special coaching classes at his Pune home where he dictated the actual questions, their options and the correct answers. The handwritten notes from those sessions later tallied exactly with the May 3 paper. Mandhare and Kulkarni are suspected to have sold question papers to over 75 students for Rs 2.5-3 lakh each. From there, the material travelled first as handwritten notes, then as PDFs, later circulated on WhatsApp and Telegram and reaching coaching hubs in Rajasthan and Maharashtra. As the probe widened, subject by subject, another Pune-based NTA expert, Manisha Sanjay Havaldar, was identified as the source for the leaked Physics questions.

Below the experts ran a broker-beneficiary layer—middlemen who mobilised students, each paying Rs 10-15 lakh for the leaked question paper. More than 60 possible scammers, many tied to Sikar's coaching ecosystem, are now under the scanner. By May 28, the CBI had arrested 13 people across Delhi, Jaipur, Gurugram, Nashik, Pune, Latur and Ahilyanagar. The NTA has roughly 24-27 setters and translators "on its radar", has questioned its entire paper-setting committee, and begun replacing its pool of experts before the retest.

Dharmendra Pradhan, the Union minister of education,

PARTLY-FOLLOWED PRESCRIPTION

The govt has failed to act on some of the 10 key recommendations of the Radhakrishnan committee, set up in June 2024 to overhaul the exam process and the NTA itself

1 Rebuild the NTA, not merely repair it. It should have an empowered governing body, three oversight sub-committees, a stronger director general, domain specialists, 10 functional verticals and two additional DGs for technology, operations, security, surveillance

Status: 16 new posts were created. Only 7 filled so far, including four after NEET-UG 2026 leak

2 The NTA should primarily conduct entrance examinations. Any expansion into other exams should happen only after its manpower, systems and institutional capacity are strengthened

Status: No new test assigned to the NTA

3 Agencies such as the UGC and CSIR should work with the NTA through the entire testing lifecycle as knowledge and examination-ethics partners, with roles fixed through MoUs and advisory bodies

Status: The heads of these institutes are already in the governing body of the NTA, but coordination is minimal

4 Establish formal institutional linkages with state and district authorities, including coordination committees, so local administration becomes part of secure test delivery rather than a passive bystander

Status: Mostly acted upon